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Original Research

Retail Design Competencies and Customer Journey Mapping Tools: A Holistic Interior Design Studio Perspective

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Abstract: This article presents a tested framework for integrating brand key analysis and customer journey mapping (CJM) as design thinking tools in the retail design studio. The aim is to enhance the knowledge and design capabilities of undergraduate interior design students, particularly in experiential retail stores. A real-life case study involved fifth-semester interior design students, who were introduced to customer experience (CX) and experiential design methodologies. After a comprehensive briefing, they designed a retail store and proposed an engaging experience for a product-based company. Over four months, students' progress was assessed by a panel of two studio instructors and two senior experienced designers from architecture and interior design. Evaluation criteria focused on proficiency in brand key analysis and CJM. Quantitative analysis revealed that while students excelled in analysis and concept design, their performance declined during the Embodiment and Detailed Design phases. Their strengths lay in identifying and articulating design problems related to brand experience, particularly in the CJM modules of attract and organizational needs. This underscores the need to prioritize skill enhancement, starting with a thorough understanding of the attract module, which addresses the complexities of retail, industry, and marketing. Additionally, focusing on organizational needs, especially the human dimension, ergonomics, and construction technologies, is essential. Ultimately, this tested framework can serve as a comprehensive guide for experiential retail design education, fostering multidisciplinary skills and knowledge.

Keywords: *Retail Interior Design Studio Education, Retail Design Competencies, Customer Journey*

Introduction

The evolving retail landscape, influenced by technological, economic, political, and socio-cultural trends, demands specialized retail designers who can adapt to these changes. Brands increasingly recognize the significant impact of retail spaces on customer experience (Petermans and Van Cleempoel 2009; Köprülü and Boz 2023). In response, design schools have developed tailored undergraduate and graduate programs. These programs are either integrated within interior design faculties or established independently to address the complexities of retail environment design.

Retail design is a unique, multidisciplinary field focused on creating customized virtual or physical environments that promote products, services, and brands (Quartier 2017). This

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specialization requires designers to build lasting connections between brands and customers, necessitating a diverse skill set that includes branding and marketing, architecture and interior design, psychology, logistics, technology integration, and user experience (UX) design (Lemon and Verhoef 2016; Ceylan 2020; Quartier 2023). A holistic approach to retail design enhances physical environments while strengthening brand presence, fostering customer loyalty, and driving business success.

Research has identified the various skills essential for effective retail design and has developed educational models applicable in both academic and professional settings (Rolla et al. 2021; Byun et al. 2012; Cheetham and Chivers 1996; Le Deist and Winterton 2005). Quartier et al. (2017, 2020, 2023) further refined these models, identifying seventy-seven advanced knowledge and design capabilities—also known as meta-competencies—vital for detailed design tasks. These competencies are organized into eight interconnected themes: research, design, socio-cultural sciences, branding, marketing and strategy, omni-channel and digital, communication, and organization and management, which shape specialized retail design education and training.

Given the dynamic nature of retailing, there is a growing need for research that integrates strategies and techniques from various fields related to retail environments. This article aims to explore the adoption of customer journey mapping (CJM) terminology and methodologies within interior design education, addressing two key research questions:

- Which competencies can be enhanced through design thinking with brand key analysis and CJM in the retail design studio?
- How can we effectively integrate brand key analysis and CJM into the retail design studio?

Literature Review

Customer Experience (CX) Tools and Methods in the Retail Design Studio

Retail designers today prioritize cultivating meaningful connections between brands and customers. They transform retail spaces into dynamic environments where customers can actively engage and establish emotional bonds (Roggeveen et al. 2021; Batat 2019). Integrating customer experience (CX) tools and focusing on meta-competencies such as commercial thinking and empathy are crucial for this customer-centric approach. These meta-competencies fall under the design competency (Di Iorio and Spagnoli 2023; Quartier et al. 2020). As consumers increasingly prioritize experiences, CX has become fundamental in various domains, shaping future strategies toward holistic, predictive approaches (Pine and Gilmore 1999; Tynan and Mckechnie 2009; Juliá Nehme et al. 2020). Designers now focus on the holistic quality of experiences, facilitated by diverse perspectives and CX tools, such as omni-channel retail execution and emotional experiences (Klingmann 2010; Gerea et al.

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2021; Lemon and Verhoef 2016). Aligning CX terminology with interior architecture and retail design further enhances this approach (Petermans et al. 2013). Consequently, research aims to equip students with CX methodologies for experiential retail design, focusing on brand analysis and CJM to craft engaging experiences (Rosenbaum et al. 2017).

The customer profile, or persona, introduced by Cooper (1999) offers insights into design and usage through qualitative and quantitative data (Pruitt and Grudin 2003). They are increasingly integrated into brand management and customer experience design (Herskovitz and Crystal 2010). Documenting target customers' demographics, socio-economic attributes, values, and needs aids in fostering empathy and building relationships (Kim et al. 2002). Micheaux and Bosio (2019) emphasize the importance of persona development using data from the customer journey. In retail design education, personas bridge creativity and understanding of target customers. Thus, as part of the case study, students were assigned to create three personas, with one serving as the primary focus. They later explored the details of all the developed personas to enhance their design thinking during the retail design studio.

Brand Key Analysis and Customer Journey Mapping

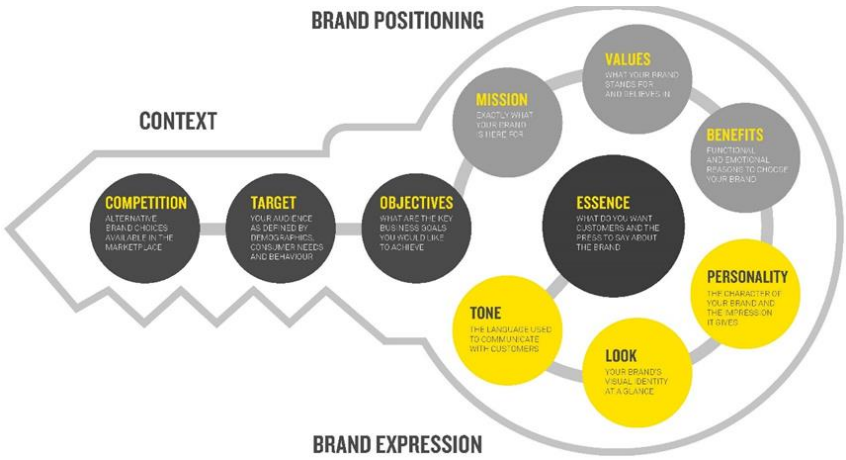
Brand Key Analysis and Customer Journey Mapping (CJM) are vital in understanding and enhancing customer experience (CX) in retail interiors. The Brand Key defines the essence of a brand, while the CJM visualizes customer interactions (Lemon and Verhoef 2016). By aligning brand messaging with the customer journey, organizations can ensure consistency and relevance throughout the customer experience (Petermans et al. 2013). Wheeler (2017) suggests six components for a comprehensive brand experience: image and identity, products and services, people and culture, sales processes, physical and virtual spaces, and awareness strategy. These components shape perceptions and emotions, influencing everything from defining brand position to sales processes and customer engagement. In this context, students in the design studio were initially introduced to several key components of the Brand Key, as illustrated in Figure 1a. These components included competition (alternative brands), target audience (demographics and behaviors), objectives (business goals), mission (the brand's purpose), values (core principles), benefits (functional and emotional reasons to choose the brand), personality (brand character), look (visual identity), (communication style), and essence (a deeper understanding of what customers and the press say about the brand).

Customers have experiences whenever they interact with any aspect of a product, service, brand, or organization, across multiple channels and at different points in time (Van de Sand et al. 2020). A Brand Key addresses both physical and virtual dimensions, guiding decisions and activities by integrating functional and creative aspects of retail design. The critical moments of interaction between the customer and any aspect of the company are referred to as "touchpoints," and a CJM is a critical "storyboard" made up of the key moments in the customer's interaction with the brand experience (Zomerdijk and Voss 2010). At each stage,

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a CJM pinpoints the essential principles and attributes to evoke the targeted rational, emotional, and behavioral responses from the brand's target audiences.

For example, Stein and Ramaseshan (2016) identified seven distinct elements of customer experience touchpoints: atmospheric, technological, communicative, process, employee–customer interaction, customer–customer interaction, and product interaction elements. Viewed through the perspective of Design Thinking, CJMs facilitate empathy with customers and aim to optimize their overall experiences (Chasanidou et al. 2015). Therefore, CJMs are invaluable tools for identifying opportunities for innovation and areas for service enhancement (Johnston and Kong 2011). Consequently, they are utilized not only by businesses but also by design/consultancy firms and experiential service providers (Stickdorn et al. 2018). The CJM Model in Figure 1b was developed by the professional experience design agency, I-AM Istanbul, to ensure that these key moments would exceed the customers' expectations and create a memorable, distinctive experience. This specific CJM Model addresses the unique challenges and considerations within the field of retail interior design and included eight different steps, including awareness, attract, threshold, orientation, browsing, interaction, purchase, and departure.



(a) Brand Key Analysis tool

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Figure 1: CX Models Utilized in the Studio: (a) Brand Key Analysis Tool, (b) Customer Journey Mapping Tool
Source: Developed by the Professional Experience Design Agency, I-AM Istanbul, 2018

Within CJM Model, the "Awareness" component is pivotal in shaping customer decisions about brands, acting as a shortcut in their decision-making process. Recognizable brands hold a clear edge in customer selection (Hoyer and Brown 1990; Huang and Sarigöllü 2012). Thus, the "awareness" aims to connect with customers across diverse channels, encompassing both traditional and digital platforms. The "attraction" component seeks to capture customers' interest in the brand by choosing the best location, crafting an appealing appearance, and encouraging brand engagement.

In the customer journey, the "threshold" marks a significant point where customers form their initial impressions of a brand and store environment. The "threshold" is essentially the entry point, both physically and metaphorically, where customers transition from the outside world into the brand's space. The "threshold" experience sets the tone for the rest of the customer journey. It is where customers start to gauge the brand's ambiance, values, and overall experience. Factors such as cleanliness, design, signage, and staff friendliness all contribute to shaping customers' initial perceptions.

The "Orientation" component acts as a guiding force, ensuring smooth navigation through the touchpoints. It minimizes confusion by providing clear pathways, incorporates engaging vistas to stimulate curiosity, and ultimately enhances satisfaction, fostering lasting connections with the brand (Schmitt 1999).

The "Browsing" module involves how customers explore various product categories, supported by relevant information and promotions. Effective marketing creates visually appealing displays, while digital enhancements provide personalized recommendations and interactive experiences to enhance engagement. The "Interaction" involves essential

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components, including service and technology models, staff presentation, and building relationships with customers. These factors shape how customers engage with services, spanning digital platforms for in-person interactions. Staff endeavors also influence customer perceptions, and building relationships fosters trust and loyalty, ultimately enhancing the overall customer journey experience. In CJM, purchase transactions integrate vital components for customers and businesses. Payment solutions, from cash to digital methods, ensure convenience driving loyalty and growth. The "Departure" is the last step of the customer journey and is crucial as it concludes the overall experience. A seamless departure, whether physical or digital, impacts customer perception and loyalty. Prioritizing digital experiences and gathering post-departure feedback are vital for enhancing satisfaction and driving advocacy (Lemon and Verhoef 2016).

The CJM depicted in Figure 1b encompasses all aspects of customer experience (CX). However, for the purposes of this article, which focuses on the design of retail interiors that involve both physical and virtual experiences, the model needed to be tailored. In this adapted version, only the modules directly related to the physical design of retail interiors were included, focusing on attract, threshold, products and services, organizational needs, orientation, and browsing.

The modules of awareness (marketing, brand advocacy, engagement, and events) and departure (feedback on customer perception and loyalty) were excluded, as they primarily pertain to omni-channel marketing activities rather than the physical experience within the retail space. Additionally, the study introduced two new modules that focus on interaction and purchasing activities within the retail interior. These modules were tailored to address the diverse offerings of "products and services" and the evolving "organizational needs" arising from experiential retailing.

A Pilot Study on Customer Experience Tools in Retail Design Studio

The pilot study was conducted at the Department of Interior Architecture and Environmental Design, Bahcesehir University, Istanbul, with the fifth-semester bachelor students. Enrolled were a total of sixty-nine students, including forty-five women and twenty-four men, with six women and five men being international students. There were eight instructors, including three full-time academicians and five part-time lecturers. Among the part-time lecturers, three were professional interior designers and two were members of the professional experience design agency. In the retail design studio (INT 3001), the students were assigned the task of designing a retail store for a product-based company by considering the dynamic changes in retailing, as well as the evolving needs and habits of customers in recent years.

Students were expected to develop an interactive sensory–spatial experience in three optional retail spaces, following a fourteen-week studio program. The project areas

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encompassed around 400 square meters within the well-known shopping center situated in Levent district of Istanbul, known for its high-income and white-collar demographic.

The assignment required students to design a concept store for a retail brand currently operating online and explore the possibility of transitioning to a physical store. In accordance with educational objectives, facilitating the transfer of feedback from experts in the retail design field was deemed crucial. Such collaborations were valuable as they provided students with practical insights and tools directly from industry professionals. They enhanced the educational experience by bridging the gap between theoretical knowledge and real-world application, preparing students for their future professional endeavors (Le Diest and Winterton 2005).Therefore, as part of the BAU Technology Transfer Office's collaboration with the Business Collaboration Unit, the studio established a collaboration with the professional experience design agency, I-AM Istanbul. This agency has been a registered "Design Center" to the Ministry of Industry and Technology in Turkey since 2020. This collaboration would enable the transfer of their know-how to the students, concerning experiential retailing, brands, and CJM tools, which were integral to their professional practices. The holistic workflow chart for the retail design project studio is shown in Figure 2.

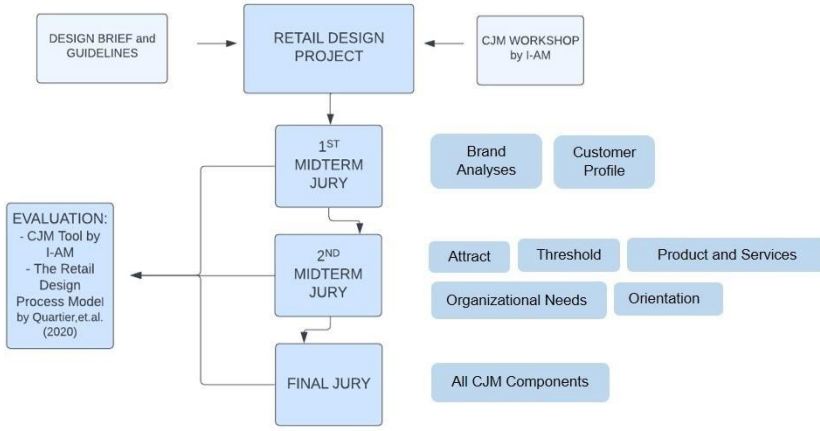


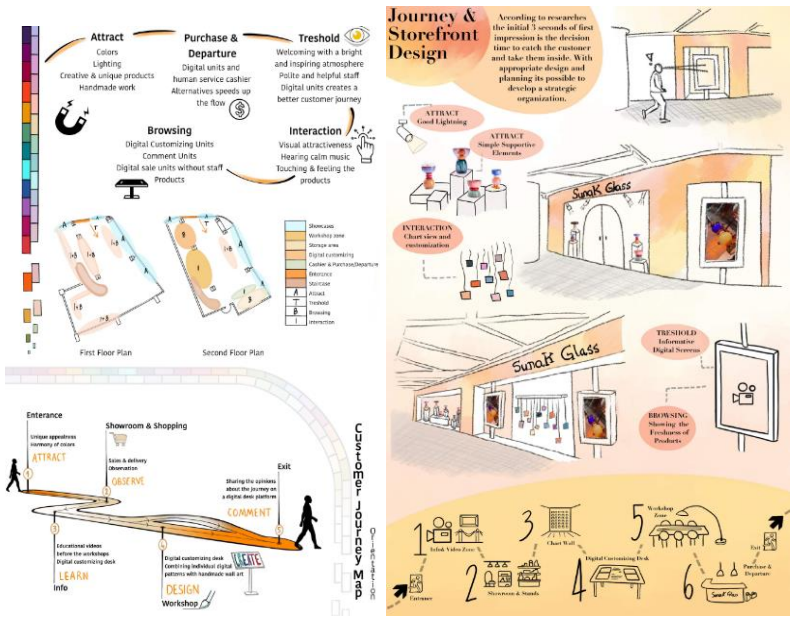
Figure 2: Holistic Workflow Established in the Retail Design Project Studio

Customer Experience and Experiential Design Workshop

The workshop took place at North Campus in Beşiktaş, within a design studio atelier, with a total of 116 enrolled students. It lasted a total of eight hours for two days. On the first day of the workshop, two members of the professional experience design agency delivered a two-hour lecture covering fundamental concepts of branding, personas—Experiential Design and Customer Experience Maps. After the lecture, students were tasked with creating A1-size posters using an image editing program. They were expected to include their selected brands, personas, customer journey maps, and initial ideas for their retail space design during a two-

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hour individual design session. On the second day, the students presented their finalized posters, which underwent evaluation during four-hour group critique sessions (Figure 3).These feedback and critique sessions were held in four separate groups, each comprising both registered students and their respective instructors.



(a) (b)

Figure 3: (a, b) Samples of Students' Work from the Customer Experience and Experiential Design Workshop

Customer Experience and Experiential Design Workshop

Following the workshop, the remaining thirteen weeks of the eight-hour weekly design studio program ensured continuous awareness and understanding of the customer experience and experiential retailing through the studio activities. The retail studio education was structured using the retail design process model of Quartier et al. (2017) and composed of Analysis Task and Concept Design, Embodiment Design, and Detailed Design phases in the following sequence. The student projects were assessed progressively through two midterm evaluations and a final jury (Table 1).

Midterm 1 addressed Analysis Tasks and Concept Design phases. The content covered was a comprehensive analysis of the site, brand, personas, and customer experience (CX) employing a range of tools such as diagrams, mapping, spatial program, keywords, matrices, storyboard, scenario, photomontage, and collages. Besides comprehensive analysis, this step involved translating these scenarios into preliminary spatial solutions. This transformation was facilitated through the development and presentation of conceptual designs, presented in the form of diagrams, models, or flow-charts, complemented by 1/100 scale technical drawings.

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Midterm 2 marked the Embodiment Design phase, which ensured the seamless translation of the creative concepts into a comprehensive and refined design. It covered the examination of improved drawings from Midterm 1, extended to the presentation of 1/50 scale technical drawings and 3D visualizations incorporating specific technical details including structural, material, and lighting solutions essential for the execution and realization of the project.

The final jury, focusing on the Detailed Designs phase, encompassed the thorough evaluation of the completed works and the overall progress achieved throughout the semester. This evaluation considered the quality of the finalized works but also the evolution and learning demonstrated by participants throughout the duration of the semester. This comprehensive approach allowed for a holistic understanding of the participants' skills, creativity, and the successful execution of the designated tasks, in alignment with the course and project requirements. Throughout the fourteen-week period, the number of submissions remained consistent. The first midterm jury, conducted in Week 5, comprised sixty-five students, while both the second jury (W 10) and the final jury (W 15) consisted of sixty-four participants each.

Materials and Methods

Methodology and Sample Group

The tested framework for tracking the improvement of students' competencies throughout the fourteen-week retail design studio process relied on two fundamental elements. Firstly, the CJM tool in Figure 1b, which students learned and utilized throughout their design journey. Secondly, the comprehensive competence framework for (future) retail design and retail design education model developed by Quartier et al. (2020), which was employed during the evaluation stages of improved competencies.

For evaluation, thirty projects were chosen based on their final jury grades, representing a range from A to A− (Excellent), B+ to B− (Good), C+ to C− (Satisfactory), and D (Failing). The numerical equivalents of letter grades were 95, 87, 82, 77, 72, 67, 62, and 47 out of 100, respectively. The selection from the high and medium-grade range was to find out which step or steps in the CJM survey held significantly influenced or challenged students during design thinking. The selected projects underwent re-evaluation based on the CJM survey developed in alignment with the research motivation (Table 1). It indicates the interconnections between brand analyses, personas analysis, and spatial design requirements in shaping meta-competencies. These components are intricately woven together and can be distinctly traced throughout the jury evaluation process.

The CJM survey was developed by two full-time studio instructors and the professional experienced designers collaborating in the studio. It was further revised by an analyst and psychologist with expertise in consumer behaviors. Within the survey, statements focusing on "brand analysis" and "personas" were essential for midterm jury 1.

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The focus then shifted to modules such as “attract,” “threshold,” “product and services,” “organizational needs,” “orientation,” and “browsing” during the midterm jury 2 assessment. All aspects were revisited in the final jury to evaluate their continued impact and relevance. The survey consisted of twenty-one statements, each answered using a five-point Likert scale (5 for “Strongly Agree” and 1 for “Strongly Disagree”).

Four respondents participated in the evaluation: two experienced design experts who introduced CX tools and methods in the retail design studio and two additional instructors with ten years of experience in retail design education for objective re-evaluation. The latter were invited from different universities to contribute to the research. They conducted blind reviews of the projects based on the statements of the CJM survey (Table 1). Subsequently, the survey scores were then compared to the jury grades using quantitative analysis. This aimed to identify the availability and deficiency of CJM modules related to the initiation or lack of competency categories (as defined by Quartier 2020) at each jury.

The evaluation included skills of Branding, Research, and Socio-cultural sciences that were intended to be acquired before midterm jury 1. It further extended to skills in Marketing and Strategy, Design and Design Activity, and Omni-channel and Digital skills, with a specific emphasis on their acquisition by midterm jury 2. Eventually, the evaluation of the final jury revealed an assessment of all acquired skills throughout the semester. Therefore, the systematic comparison of students’ grades and survey scores revealed the strengths and weaknesses, as well as the opportunities and threats of the retail design studio process.

To elaborate, the initial three statements in the survey, covered by Midterm 1, were designed to assess the incorporation of “brand analysis” into the project. These statements assessed the participant’s branding ability to effectively analyze the expectations and goals of their chosen brand.

This part also inquired about his/her proficiency in selecting a brand that aligned with the project space, essentially exploring how well a student established a cohesive relationship between brand identity and the project area. The following statements pertained to the “personas” and scored competencies related to the research and socio-cultural sciences categories.

For “persona” analysis, which necessitated Marketing and Strategy skills, the initial emphasis was on evaluating how the interaction between the brand and the customers manifested in the project space. Furthermore, the assessment included examining the alignment of the brand with the persona. The analysis also involved evaluating how well the developed design addressed the expectations and needs of the customers according to their psychological, social, and intellectual profiles (Table 1).

Evaluated in midterm jury 2, the Embodiment Design phase (Figure 1b) required the design of “attract,” “threshold,” “product and services,” “organizational needs,” and “orientation and browsing” components of the CJM. Among all, the statements within the

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"attract" module focused on designing attractive and engaging showcase displays, emphasizing their correlation with the brand identity and persona.

This emphasis placed particular importance on Marketing and Strategy skills. The four components, namely "threshold," "product and services," "organizational needs," and "orientation" of the CJM, primarily relied on Design and Design Activity skills. The "threshold," component encompassed the interior atmosphere, color scheme, materials, textures, and furniture, all interwoven with the brand's identity. The exploration delved into the connection between the entrance/exit areas of the store and the user's physical and sensory requirements.

Additionally, an analysis was conducted on how in-store guidance elements influenced the final project outputs, including plans, sections, and detailed drawings. Within the "product and services" category, the objective was to assess the student's comprehension and proficiency in understanding the physical spatial requirements essential for retail design. The statements encompassed the strategic planning and implementation of in-store product placement, organization of display elements, and positioning of rest/waiting points, all while considering the square meter area in compliance with building regulations.

The "organizational needs" module involved proficiency in comprehending the human dimension and ergonomics within store design. It also evaluated the student's capability to make crucial decisions during the design process of construction and building technologies, encompassing interior and furniture design. The "orientation" component involved the comprehension of the interrelationship among service and functional areas in alignment with building regulations. Finally, the "browsing" component, referred to Omni-channel and Digital skills, comprised statements aimed at acquiring knowledge and proficiency in the design of physical and digital experiential areas within a retail design (Table 1).

Table 1: The Assessment Framework Includes Modules That Measure the Success Rate of Customer Journey Mapping (CJM)

Design Studio Evaluation	*CJM*	*CJM Surveying Statements*	*Meta-competencies by Quartier et al.*
Midterm 1 Jury Requirements			
Analysis Task	*Brand Analyses*		*Branding*
Analysis of Project Brief		1. I think that the expectations/targets of the brand were determined correctly in the project	—Has knowledge and understanding of branding —Has knowledge and understanding of brand communication Socio-cultural sciences —Has knowledge and understanding of psychology
-Given space and its potential (near surroundings, circulation, spatial volume, vista, usage of direction) - Analysis of Brand and Persona (scenario) - Products/services that the brand provides - Brand mission and vision		2. The identity of the brand analyzed in the	—Has knowledge and understanding of sociology

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- Digital and Physical Experiences Experiential retail and research on sensorial, emotional, and psychological expectations of users - The highlight of the brand - Competitors - Persona		project is compatible with the identity of the project area (Kanyon).	
		3. The concept developed by the student for the brand coincides with the identity of the chosen brand.	—Has knowledge and understanding of philosophy
Concept Design			
-Concept Development Develop a concept on given spatial and functional requirements defined by a scenario and product displaying, selling, storing, shopping (experiencing, socializing, relaxation, accompanying, entertaining, etc.) - Concept Board Presentation - Mood-board - Spatial Organization (scheme with diagrams, models, and/or flow-chart)	*Persona*	4. The main goal of the brand and the persona of the project are compatible.	Research —The ability to understand and analyze the target group, consumer behavior and the customer journey —Awareness of trends and the ability to analyze them
		5. The design of the store responds to the sensory/functional needs and expectations of the persona	Socio-cultural sciences —Has knowledge and understanding of psychology, sociology, and philosophy
Midterm 2 Jury Requirements	*Attract*	6. I think the showcase design of the store reflects the brand identity.	Marketing and Strategy —Has knowledge and understanding of retail marketing and strategy
Embodiment Design			
Concept Development - Concept Board Presentation - 1/100 Plan View expected to present zonings of specified functional areas (layout) 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions. 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions.		7. I think the showcase design of the store is distinctive from similar ones	—Understanding the retail industry and the operations/activities within a store
		8. The showcase design is interesting for the user	—Has knowledge and understanding of scent marketing
Midterm 2 Jury Requirements		9. The store's atmosphere (color, material, texture, furniture) coincides with the brand's identity.	Design and Design Activity —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies and the ability to develop technical drawings
Embodiment Design			
Concept Development - Concept Board Presentation	*Threshold*	10. I think that the entrance/exit areas of	Design and Design Activity

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- 1/100 Plan View expected to present zonings ofspecified functional areas (layout) - 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions. - 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions. Detailed Design - Technical drawings - 1/50 Plans - 1/50 Sections - 1/50 Reflected Ceiling Plan - 1/50 Facade Elevations - 1/20 Partial Plan and Section from a selected partial area *Midterm 2 Jury Requirements*		the store can meet the sensory needs of the user.	—Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies and the ability to develop technical drawings —Knowledge and understanding of computer software (CAD, graphical, 3D, and rendering software) and the ability to develop plans, 2D and 3D visualizations with them
Embodiment Design Concept Development - Concept Board Presentation - 1/100 Plan View expected to present zonings ofspecified functional areas (layout) - 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions. - 1/100 Section (given)—according to limits of the given project area and proposed functions.	*Threshold Product and Services*	11. I think that the user (customer) entrance and exit areas in the project support each other. 12. I think that in-store orientation elements are used effectively. 13. I think product placement/display (size, material, detail) can respond to functional requirements. 14. I think that the resting/waiting points in the space (its location, the area it covers) can meet the functional requirements.	Design and Design Activity —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies and the ability to develop technical drawings —Knowledge and understanding of computer software (CAD, graphical, 3D, and rendering software) and the ability to develop plans, 2D and 3D visualizations with them —Knowledge and understanding of (building) regulations
Detailed Design - Technical drawings - 1/50 Plans - 1/50 Sections - 1/50 Reflected Ceiling Plan	*Product and Services Organizational Needs*	15. I think that the cashier area (its location, the area it occupies) can meet the functional requirements.	—Knowledge and understanding of (building) regulations —Knowledge and understanding of the human dimension and ergonomics —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies make critical choices during the design process

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- 1/50 Facade Elevations - 1/20 Partial Plan and Section from a selected partial area.		16. I think that the management behind the cashier area can respond to the spatial requirements (location within the space).	—Knowledge and understanding of (building) regulations —Knowledge and understanding of the human dimension and ergonomics —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies make critical choices during the design process
		17. I think that the storage area can meet the spatial requirements (m2, layout) when considering the products/services.	—Knowledge and understanding of the human dimension and ergonomics —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies make critical choices during the design process
	Organizational Needs Orientation	18. The circulation created in the store is suitable for service.	—Knowledge and understanding of the human dimension and ergonomics —Knowledge and understanding of (furniture) construction and building technologies make critical choices during the design process —Knowledge and understanding of (building) regulations Omni-channel and Digital —Awareness of digital developments and understanding of the functioning and application of digital solutions
		19. The circulation created in the store is convenient for users.	
	Orientation Browsing	20. In the design, digital experience areas have been created for the user by the concept.	—Knowledge and understanding of (building) regulations Omni-channel and Digital —Awareness of digital developments and understanding of the functioning and application of digital solutions Omni-channel and Digital —Awareness of digital developments and understanding of the functioning and application of digital solutions
		21. In the design, physical experience areas have been created for the user by the concept.	

Data Analysis

Through quantitative analysis, each CJM module was initially weighted according to the survey scores provided by the reviewers. Subsequently, the progress of students in each category of the CJM survey was evaluated by comparing midterm jury 1 (Analysis Task and

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Concept Design), midterm jury 2 (Embodied Design and Detailed Design), and final jury grades. Finally, by comparing both datasets, the impact of the Analysis and Concept and Embodiment and Detailed Design stages on developing students' competency in designing retail interiors was assessed.

The entire statistical analysis was performed using SPSS (Statistical Package for the Social Sciences) version 27.0 and employed a five-point Likert scale. The significance level for the study was set at $\alpha = .05$. In the evaluation of the study data, descriptive statistical measures were employed for continuous data, encompassing mean, standard deviation, minimum, and maximum values. Furthermore, frequency and percentage distributions were provided for categorical data. Normality tests, including the Kolmogorov–Smirnov and Shapiro–Wilk Tests, were conducted, revealing that the data exhibited a normal distribution.

Consequently, an ANOVA (Analysis of Variance) test was conducted to compare three or more independent groups, followed by a post-hoc analysis using the Tukey test.

For comparisons between two groups, independent sample *t*-tests were applied. Additionally, paired *t*-tests were used to analyze differences within dependent groups.

Findings

This section presents the analysis results. The average grade level in Analysis and Concept Design is 3.60, while the average grade level in Embodiment and Detailed Design is 3.17 (Table 2). In the Analysis Task and Concept Design phase, the highest value is typically obtained in the "brand analysis," with a mean value of 3.64 (±.41), indicating agreement with related statements in Table 2. As outlined in Table 3, the highest values are achieved by Statement 2 (The identity of the brand analyzed in the project is compatible with the identity of the project area) with a mean of 3.65, followed by Statement 4 (The main goal of the brand and the persona of the project are compatible) with a value of 3.64.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics for CJM Components

	Mean	*Std. Deviation*	*Minimum*	*Maximum*
Analysis + Concept Design	3.60	0.41	2.92	4.50
Brand Analyses	3.64	0.42	2.92	4.50
Persona	3.57	0.44	2.75	4.50
Embodiment and Detailed Design	3.17	0.32	2.49	4.10
Attract	2.88	0.69	1.83	4.17
Threshold	3.20	0.37	2.50	4.13
Product and Services	3.26	0.42	2.50	4.33
Organizational Needs	2.84	0.47	1.75	3.63
Orientation	3.46	0.38	2.13	4.25
Browsing	3.41	0.50	2.25	4.50

Note: Five-point Likert scale; 5–Strongly Agree, 4–Agree, 3–Neutral, 2–Disagree, 1–Strongly Disagree.

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Meanwhile, Statement 1 (I think that the expectations/targets of the brand were determined correctly in the project) records a mean value of 3.63, while Statement 3 (The concept developed by the student for the brand coincides with the identity of the chosen brand) and Statement 5 (The design of the store responds to the sensory/functional needs and expectations of the persona) obtains values of 3.61 and 3.50, respectively (Table 3).

Table 3: Evaluators' Highest and Lowest Scores

CJM Survey Tool Statements	*Reviewer 1*	*Reviewer 2*	*Reviewer 3*	*Reviewer 4*	*Mean*
Analysis +Concept Design					
S.1 I think that the expectations/targets of the brand were determined correctly in the project.	4.06	3.3	3.96	3.23	3.63
S.2 The identity of the brand analyzed in the project is compatible with the identity of the project area (Kanyon).	4.03	3.8	4.03	2.76	3.65
S.3 The concept developed by the student for the brand coincides with the identity of the chosen brand.	4	3.1	3.86	3.46	3.61
S.4 The main goal of the brand and the persona of the project are compatible.	3.93	3.7	3.73	3.2	3.64
S.5 The design of the store responds to the sensory/functional needs and expectations of the persona.	3.96	2.96	3.93	3.13	3.50
Embodiment and Detailed Design					
S.11 I think that the user/customer entrance–exit areas in the project support each other.	3.63	3.03	3.83	3.9	3.60
S.12 I think that in-store orientation elements are used effectively.	2.96	2.93	2.5	1.56	2.49
S.19 The circulation created in the store is convenient for users.	3.86	3.06	3.9	3.6	3.61
S.21 In the design, physical experience areas have been created for the user by the concept.	3.7	3.2	3.83	3.8	3.63

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The Embodiment and Detailed Design stage exhibits a mean value of 3.17 (±.32), which is relatively lower than the Analysis and Concept Design phase. Responses for these categories were generally marked as "I am uncertain" by the reviewers.

The scoring for the CJM modules within Embodiment and Detailed Design yields the mean values as follows: 2.88 (±.69) for "attract," 3.20 (±.37) for "threshold," 3.26 (±.42) for "products and services," 2.84 (±.47) (the lowest) for "organizational needs," 3.46 (±.38) (the highest) for "orientation," and 3.41 (±.50) for "browsing" categories (Table 2).

In Table 3, the highest competency value points with a mean value of 3.63, are attributed to Statement 21 (In the design, physical experience areas have been created for the user by the concept) related to Omni-channel and Digital skills. It is followed by statements that require Design and Design Activity skills which are the "orientation" Statement 19 (The circulation created in the store is convenient for users) with a mean value 3.61, and "threshold" Statement 11 (I think that the user/customer entrance–exit areas in the project support each other) with mean value 3.60. The lowest score in the Embodiment and Detailed Design category is the mean value of 2.49 for Statement 12 (I think that in-store orientation elements are used effectively) under the "threshold" subheading.

When the midterm 1 jury grades distribution is reviewed for the Analysis and Concept Design phase; the breakdown is as follows: 6.7% failing, 20% satisfactory, 33.3% good, and 40% excellent. The second midterm design jury grades distribution for Embodiment and Detailed Design is; 3.3% failing, 16.7% satisfactory, 33.3% good, and 46.7% excellent. Analysis of the final jury grades reveals that there are no failing grades; instead, 3.3% of the grades are satisfactory, 53.3% are good, and 43.3% are excellent (Table 4).

Table 4: Descriptive Statistics for Grade Groups and Percentage Distributions

Grade Groups	*Grade*	*n*	*%*
Analysis + Concept Design (First Midterm Grade)	failing	2	6.7
	satisfactory	6	20.0
	good	10	33.3
	excellent	12	40.0
Embodiment and Detailed Design (Second Midterm Grade)	failing	1	3.3
	satisfactory	5	16.7
	good	10	33.3
	excellent	14	46.7
Final Grade	failing	-	-
	satisfactory	1	3.3
	good	16	53.3
	excellent	13	43.3

Note: Jury grades categories as follows: A– A– (Excellent); B+, B, B– (Good); C+, C, C– (Satisfactory); and D (Failing), according to the Bahcesehir University evaluation system.

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The paired Samples test result underlined a significant difference between the first midterm jury and final jury grades for the Analysis and Concept Design ($t = 2.963$, $p < .05$). The final jury grade value is significantly higher (mean = 3.40). For the Embodiment and Detailed Design, no significant difference is determined among the second and last jury grades ($t = 1.045$, $p > .05$) (Table 5). In summary, students enhanced their skills in analysis tasks and concept design from midterm to final exam, while maintaining similar performance levels in devising design and detailing solutions for retail interiors.

Table 5: Paired Samples Test Result

Grade Groups		*Mean*	*n*	*Std. Deviation*	*t Stat.*	*p*
Pair 1	First midterm jury: Analysis + Concept design	3.0667	30	.94443	2.96	.03*
	Final jury: Analysis + Concept design	3.4000	30	.56324		
Pair 2	Second midterm jury: Embodiment and Detailed Design	3.2333	30	.85836	1.04	.25
	Final jury: Embodiment and Detailed Design	3.4000	30	.56324		

*Significant at .05 level.

Based on the analysis results, it is evident that students with good and excellent grades tend to excel in brand analysis and customer profiling. For the Embodiment and Detailed Design, there is no significant difference between the grade groups and the CJM components in the second midterm jury ($p > .05$) (Table 5). Significant differences were observed in survey evaluations of students with excellent and good final grades, especially in "orientation" (mean 3.48) followed by "products and services" (mean 3.28) categories ($p < .05$) (Table 6).

Table 6: Correlation Matrix of Embodiment and Detailed Design Based on Survey Results and Final Grades

CJM Tool Components	*Final Grade*	*n*	*Mean Scores*	*Std. Deviation*	*F*	*p*	*Post-Hoc*
Attract	Satisfactory	1	2.33		1.114	.255	
	Good	16	2.81	.65			
	Excellent	13	2.99	.76			
Threshold	Satisfactory	1	2.88		1.168	.117	
	Good	16	3.16	.31			
	Excellent	13	3.29	.43			

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Product and Service	Satisfactory	1	2.67		5.902	.024*	3 > 1, 3 > 2
	Good	16	3.14	.33			
	Excellent	13	3.45	.44			
Organizational Needs	Satisfactory	1	2.63		.885	.236	
	Good	16	2.85	.49			
	Excellent	13	2.84	.48			
Orientation	Satisfactory	1	3.00		4.386	.038*	3 > 1, 3 > 2
	Good	16	3.33	.40			
	Excellent	13	3.67	.27			
Browsing	Satisfactory	1	2.63		1.342	.159	
	Good	16	3.45	.53			
	Excellent	13	3.67	.27			
Embodiment and Detailed Design	Satisfactory	1	2.69		1.277	.107	
	Good	16	3.12	.28			
	Excellent	13	3.28	.34			

*Significant at .05 level.

Discussion and Conclusion

This article aims to investigate the development of meta-competencies in retail design among undergraduate design students, following the integration of CX tools as design thinking methodologies in the interior design studio. The case study specifically focused on crafting the in-store customer journey, which encompassed defining the brand, identifying its customers and concept, designing the physical store, selecting design elements, and optimizing both physical and digital touchpoints. Once students became familiar with brand analysis, CJM, and CX terminology, they applied these concepts in their projects throughout the semester. A quantitative analysis of the highest-scoring projects revealed the students' strengths and weaknesses in designing experiential retail environments. Based on these findings, a framework has been introduced that links the success rate of applied CJM components with the enhancement of retail design competencies (Figure 4). This holistic framework aims to facilitate the tracking of knowledge acquisition and design proficiency among undergraduate interior design students, particularly in the realm of experiential retail. Consequently, the case study provided the necessary context to address the following research questions:

- Which competencies can be enhanced through design thinking with brand key analysis and CJM in the experiential retail design studio?
- How can we integrate brand key analysis and CJM into the experiential retail design studio?

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The statements regarding Brand Analysis and Concept Design received relatively high scores (mean value of 3.60) compared to the Embodiment + Detailed Design stage (mean value of 3.17) from the reviewers, indicating general agreement on enhanced skills (Table 2). These scores displayed significant improvement from the first midterm to the final exam (mean = 3.40) (Table 5). Particularly, Statement 2 (The identity of the brand analyzed in the project is compatible with the identity of the project area) received positive evaluations, suggesting successful branding and communication within students' projects (Table 3). Furthermore, students demonstrated the ability to determine target personas and understand current consumption trends, showcasing empathy through their research and socio-cultural competencies (Table 1).

During the Embodiment + Detailed Design stage, students maintained relatively lower performance levels (Table 2). The weakest categories, graded with the lowest mean scores, were "organizational needs" (2.84) and "attract" (2.88) (Table 2). The "organizational needs" category assessed students' ability to comprehend the human dimension and ergonomics in-store design, as well as their capacity to make critical decisions involving construction and building technologies, including interior and furniture design. Integrating intensive lectures and workshop sessions into the course curriculum could effectively enhance students' proficiency in this category. Moreover, the "attract" category aimed to assess students' effectiveness in creating impactful store designs and increasing brand engagement for their target personas in their projects. Additionally, the lowest score (mean value: 2.49) in the "threshold" subheading (Statement 12: I think that in-store orientation elements are used effectively) indicated that students lacked competency in design skills that could enhance customer experience through multimedia utilization (Table 3). From these findings, the necessity of understanding Design and Design Activity and Marketing and Strategy skills became apparent, particularly for a more multidisciplinary and holistic approach to retail design studios.

Due to survey results, the orientation category stood out as an area where students with high final grades were more successful than in the products and services (Table 6).

Thus, it was evident that a significant competency that students developed in their projects was orientation, which involves understanding the correlation between service and functional areas while adhering to building regulations. This fell under the meta-competence of Design and Design Activity. It appeared that another domain where competence was cultivated through projects was within the realm of products and services. Another component identified as strong in students' project evaluations was browsing, which targeted the acquisition of knowledge and proficiency in designing physical and digital experiential spaces within retail store design (Figure 4).

According to the survey results, the "threshold" emerged as the final CJM component where students exhibited strength in the Embodiment and Detailed Design project phase. This component encompassed the integration of the store environment, color, materials, and

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furniture with the brand. It also examined the connections between entrances/exits and user needs while assessing the influence of orientation elements on project outcomes in the studio. The "threshold" aspect pertained to design disciplines and activities, emphasizing the translation of knowledge into the development of technical drawings.

Regarding the second research question, findings from the quantitative analysis revealed that students' performance in brand analysis and concept design did not maintain consistency during the Embodiment and Detailed Design phases. Their proficiency lay more in identifying and articulating design problems related to brand experience, rather than devising solutions, especially for some of the CJM modules such as "attract" and "organizational needs." While the former highlighted the significance of understanding retail marketing and strategy requirements, the latter emphasized focusing on aspects such as human dimension, ergonomics, and building and construction technologies. By providing a structured approach to learning and assessment, this tested framework could facilitate the development of multidisciplinary skills and knowledge necessary for experiential retail design (Figure 4).

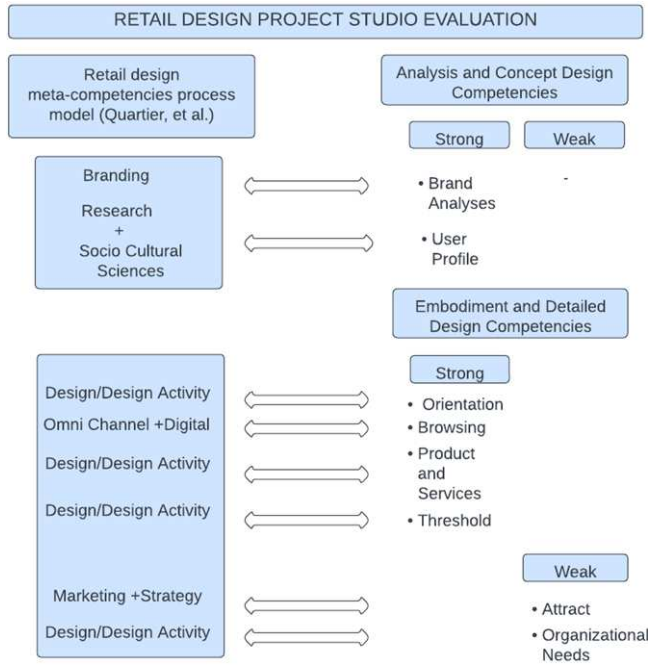


Figure 4: Assessing Strengths and Weaknesses of the CJM Components in Retail Design Studio

The workflow used in this research encouraged students to analyze every key moment of the entire customer experience, taking into account all physical and digital touchpoints throughout the in-store journey.

Besides, they developed the skill of seamlessly integrating brand elements into their interior design approach, drawing upon consumer insights gathered from the brand key

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module. Furthermore, the engagement of both researchers and practitioners facilitated the transfer of knowledge between professionals and academia.

This holistic approach equips students with the fundamental skills necessary for experiential retail store design, including commercial thinking, empathy, innovation, and holistic thinking, which have been emphasized in previous models of retail design education. The tested framework encompasses all stages of the retail design studio education, linking student submissions with their enhanced competencies. Consequently, it facilitates the identification of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats within retail design studio education, highlighting the need for a more comprehensive curriculum that integrates associated courses within the department.

Upon implementing the workflow in Table 1, the enhancement observed in the Analysis + Concept Design phase indicated that workshops and lectures held during the course positively impacted student performance. Although students successfully crafted a strong concept and analysis, they faced limitations in fully realizing and detailing the design. This indicates that despite exhibiting robust conceptual and analytical abilities, students encountered difficulties in translating these aspects into tangible design elements. The lower mean value observed for the Embodiment and Detailed Design offer a foundational basis for further analysis and the development of action plans aimed at enhancing this stage, taking into account the identified strengths and weaknesses within each category. Alternatively, the program could be tailored to foster collaboration between the core courses and the design studio. For example, additional workshops could be implemented to focus on areas that require specialized knowledge such as the human dimension, ergonomics, building and construction technologies, along with furniture design, visual design, and graphic communication. Such initiatives would not only enhance the educational experience but also better equip students to meet industry demands effectively.

Limitations

This article has several noteworthy limitations. Firstly, in the case study, the task briefing given to students was constrained by both scope and time limitations. It focused on experiential retail stores and directed their attention toward lesser-known niche retail brands that had predominantly operated online and lacked a physical presence. The objective was to avoid duplicating the identities of the most well-known brands. The duration and sample size of the research were determined by the semester and the number of students enrolled in the course. The sample size is relatively small, restricting the generalizability of the results. A potential future objective for the authors could involve conducting a comparative retail design studio in collaboration with other design schools. However, expanding the analysis to include a larger group of students could make it challenging to conduct workshops effectively in a design studio, where one-on-one communication is crucial. Additionally, incorporating

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work from other semesters would require addressing the evolving needs and expectations of users over time.

Secondly, it would be advantageous to delve deeper into the discrepancies in grade distribution between each midterm and final juries, taking into account additional variables such as student background and learning style.

Nonetheless, the aim of this study was to investigate the immediate statistical effects of CX integration on the overall class. Individual design solutions were not included in this scope.

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Informed Consent

The authors have obtained informed consent from all participants.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest.

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